EPSOM U3A Inc.

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Website https://u3aepsom.nz/.

MEETING PLACE

Royal Oak Bowls, 146 Selwyn St, Onehunga

10am on the 2ND Thursday of most months

NEWSLETTER

APRIL 2026

Next meeting
10-12noon
Thursday 9 April 2026

In the time since we last met, the committee and I have discussed a working paper put out by an organisation in the UK similar to ours; U3A Friends. It comes to us via the U3A Auckland Network – I have copied it below. It makes interesting reading.

The paper makes pertinent observations about how our rapidly changing society must inevitably change the makeup of U3A's membership and therefore alter the expectations of what future members want from U3A; it may be very different from what we – today – are content with.

The questions raised in the discussion paper are not an urgent call to action by any means, but they are food for thought. They are very real issues of which we should take cognisance. So, over the next few months, the committee will be seeking your thoughts and opinions on what – if anything – all this means for us. It may well be the opinion of a majority that we let U3A evolve naturally as demographics and society in general are similarly developing. Alternatively, it is possible that there will be consideration to move towards some anticipation of society's trends in some ways that we have yet to debate.

I don't think there are any right or wrong answers as to how we react to this paper. But we do need to be aware that it signals something of which we should take notice.

Some excerpts from the U3A Friends newsletter 2026 gives us:

- Ageing population – longer retirements
- Retirement age increasing and less formal – 70 is the new 50
- But many now have increased caring responsibilities
- Greater risk of loneliness and isolation, especially post-Covid
- Smart phones, Zoom, WhatsApp, Social Media are prominent
- Huge increase in travel and tourism spending amongst over 65s
- Decline in volunteering being seen across the sector
- Society is more diverse in background & culture

The Next Generation:

Generation X (1965-1980) will be the next generation of u3a members

- More tech-literate
- Grew up with rapid technological change, globalisation and huge social mobility
- More individualistic, valuing flexibility and variety
- Later and less formal retirement
- Less financially secure in later life
- More care responsibilities - the sandwich generation

What does this all mean for u3a?

- Our membership will increase and be more varied; the next generation of members will have very different backgrounds and expectations – need for flexibility and new ideas to meet their needs.
- Our role in fostering community and combatting loneliness is more important than ever.
- We need to embrace digital tools while supporting members less confident with tech – and follow trends in digital marketing and comms to reach and engage a new generation.
- We are no longer seen as just a learning organisation – community, connection and fun are key.
- We must make every effort to attract a wider range of members and reflect our increasingly diverse society.
- We must play a role in promoting a positive approach to later life.
- Need to rethink how we recruit, support and retain volunteers as their expectations change.

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Legal Advisor
Mike Matson – 022 630 7968
Newsletter
Jeanette Grant – 638 8566
Greeters:
Don Buchanan - 620 7572
Ngaire Mune – 624 0226

INTEREST GROUP CONVENERS

Applied Sciences
Peter Parsons - 021 521446
Attending Performing Arts
Shirin Caldwell – 630 1662
Architecture
Brian Murray – 021 026 68396
Art Appreciation
Kaye Buchanan – 620 7572
Art History
Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094
Big History
Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094
Book Chat
Helen Holdem - 021 260 3510
Chess Group
John Locke - - 021-187 8061
Comparative Religions
Duncan MacDonald - 021-316 661 John Locke- 021-187 8061
Current Affairs
Shirley McConville – 622 3542
Fabric & Fibre Crafts
Charmaine Strang – 027-4177 556
Famous & Infamous Group
Shirley McConville – 622 3542
Foodies
Graham Gunn – 027 445 0929.
Garden Appreciation
Betty Townley - 626 6673
Introduction to Family History
Bryn Smith – 027 280 5235
Latin
Phylllis Downes – 630 5867
Lunch Bunch
Shirley McConville – 622 3542.
Music Appreciation
Carleen Edwards – 624 6298
History & Social Change
Helen Holdem – 021 260 3510
NZ History
Kaye Buchanan - 620 7572
Philosophy
Jocelyn Hewin - 634-1552
Scrabble
Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680
Te Reo Maori
Jenny Whatman – 027 353 2487
Travel
Diana Hart- 021 284 4402
Walkers & Talkers Group
Don Buchanan ph:620 7572.

MARCH SPEAKER REPORT	**On 12th March, to mark World Kidney Day, our speaker, Joanne Hand from the Kidney Society of New Zealand,** explained that they seek to promote awareness of kidney disease which is often symptomless until it becomes serious. Up to 90% loss of function can occur before symptoms become obvious. They offer practical assistance and wrap-around support to those who need it ; community dialysis houses, home-based visits, etc. In the general population of NZ, one in ten suffers from chronic kidney disease (CKD) but in the over-65s, that figure rises to almost half. Kidney disease is a threat to the elderly. **Why are kidneys vital for good health?** Kidneys filter toxins and excess fluid from blood, control blood pressure, balance electrolytes, and produce hormones that support bone health and red blood cell production. As damage cannot be reversed, **symptoms** to look out for, so kidney disease can be caught early and treated, are as follows: **K-**Killer cramps, **I**-Itchy skin, **D**-Dietary taste changes, **N**-Nausea or vomiting, **E**-Exhaustion **Y**- Your urine has blood in it or is foamy **Modifiable risk factors** for prevention of kidney disease are tackling obesity, not smoking, controlling overconsumption of alcohol, treating high blood pressure, and limiting overuse of pain medications. **Prevention includes**: -NB- Having GP Warrant of Fitness check-ups annually, with blood or urine tests to look for proteins and creatinine which are markers for kidney problems. -Taking care of the body with healthy diet, low in salt, low in sugar and staying well hydrated. -Avoid excessive alcohol and smoking -Be open with your GP about supplements taken, or drinks that could cause bad interactions with medications and damage the kidneys. **Non-Modifiable factors** are genetics, Damage and Aging Globally, kidney disease is the 9th leading cause of death, and this could be higher as kidneys are often damaged due to other conditions eg. Heart disease. Further information can be gained by using the Kidney Society's website or Facebook page. You can also sign up for their magazine or ring them with any concerns. Donors of money can support special projects. Eg Supplying new reclining chairs for dialysis patients. **What does the Kidney Society Do to assist diagnosed people?** 1 Provides 3 homes in South Auckland, with Te Whatu Ora Counties Manukau support, for dialysis patients to attend. This allows 56 people to dialyse independently without having to go to Middlemore hospital. They would like to expand this around NZ in the future, but would need government or private funding to do so. West Auckland will be the next venue for a dialysis house. 2 Runs a wellness support programme, follows up clients' equipment needs, supplies brochures about maintaining strength and health and provides evidence-based information. 3 Runs in-the-community and online education sessions, linked to local experts and professionals. 4 Makes referrals, collaborates with health professionals and provides peer support buddies for people undergoing treatment. 5 Promotes good nutrition via Foodie Fridays on Facebook, which gives recipes and advice on eating healthily. 6 Aims to remove health system barriers and to empower the client. Helps clients set their own goals
SUBSCRIPTIONS INFORMATION	The 2026 Epsom U3A subscription is $50 per person This should be paid into our ASB bank account – Payee: U3A EPSOM INCORPORATED 12 – 3067 – 0204618 – 00 Please enter subs in the "code" section and your name in the "reference" section in order for us to have a record of your payment. Our current membership totals 210, of whom only three do not use email.
APRIL SPEAKER	Our April speaker is Peter Wharton. Peter is an adventurer who has storm-chased in the USA, travelled to Base Camp at Everest, and sailed through some of the wildest parts of the world including the Falklands, Drake Passage and Antarctica. His talk to us will concentrate on his thirty-three day, 3,000 nautical mile voyage in the Barque, Europa to Antarctica. In his own words, "I hope to give you a sense of the raw intensity of getting up close and personal with this rugged part of the world, all wrapped up in the romance of a grand sailing tradition."

INTEREST GROUPS	**U3A Comparative Religions group**. Convenors: John Locke and Duncan Macdonald. The group meets on the second Friday of the month at 10am. The Comparative Religions group was established in July 2024. The group currently has ten members, but anyone is welcome to join. The main aim of the group is to make members more aware of the philosophy, doctrine and rituals of religions, particularly the monotheistic religions such as Christianity, Judaism, Islam and Buddhism. The group does not advocate or promote a particular belief system. This year, we will be concentrating on the impact of religious beliefs on politics, economics, and social beliefs and attitudes. The group will also visit various religious institutions throughout the year. In March 2026, the group was fortunate enough to visit the synagogue of the Auckland Hebrew Congregation in Remuera Road. Kadima School is also part of the synagogue complex. The staff at the synagogue were very helpful and welcoming and they gave group members a great insight into Jewish beliefs, rituals and practices. A highlight of the visit was a conducted tour of the Holocaust Memorial Garden in the synagogue grounds. This beautiful but sombre memorial is a grim reminder of the greatest catastrophe to befall the Jewish people. The group plans to visit the cathedral in Parnell in May and other institutions throughout the year. Reminder: please Convenors and members consider sending a short summary regarding any news from their interest groups for our future newsletters to Bill/Joslyn. Thank you!
ODDMENTS	Kenya & Tanzania and Madagascar Reforestation Projects. ww.forevertrees.nz In over two decades of owning and running an international adventure travel company, leading cycle tours around the world, we witnessed deforestation and environmental degradation happening before our eyes. This prompted us to incorporate tree planting into our tours, working with local nurseries and environmental groups. Keen to know more? Get in touch: john@forevertrees.nz or https://www.forevertrees.nz/travel - John & Mandy Forever Trees 18 Koura Road, Atawhai, Nelson 7010, NZ, 027 2978855
2026 MEETING DATES Thursdays, 10am	9 April 14 May 11 June 9 July 13 August 10 September 8 October 12 November AGM **NB Always wear your name badge** and be seated ready at 10am

u3a Auckland Network welcomes you to a day of celebration

Salvation Army Church, 18 Allright Place, Mt Wellington

Saturday 25 July 2026 - 9:30am (for 10:00am) to 2:30pm

Speakers:

Morning: Dame Wendy Pye - "Teaching the World to Read."

Afternoon: Shamubeel Eaqub - "A Society Worth Having."

Also included are four presentations by u3a Members and lunch - $50.00

Go to u3a.nz/event to register

JEANETTE'S JOTTINGS

VERONIKA THE COW – TOOL-USER

A cow with 'extraordinary intelligence' has been discovered in the Austrian village of Carinthia.

Veronika shocked researchers as she became the first documented case of a cow working out how to use a tool. Witgar Wiegele, an organic farmer and baker, had kept Veronika as a pet for more than 10 years when he noticed her special abilities. Veronika could recognise different family members' voices and would hurry off to meet them. But, most impressively of all, Veronika started playing with sticks and eventually learned to scratch herself with them.

A paper published on January 19 in the journal Current Biology argues that this is the first recorded case of a pet cow learning to use a tool. In a series of controlled trials, they placed a deck brush on the ground in random orientations and recorded which end Veronika chose and which part of her body she targeted. Across repeated sessions, her choices were consistent and suited to the body regions she was scratching.

Co–author Antonio Osuna–Mascaró, a post–doctoral researcher, said: *'Veronika is not just using an object to scratch herself. She uses different parts of the same tool for different purposes, and she applies different techniques depending on the function of the tool and the body region.'*

FLYING UMBRELLA

Walking in the rain with an umbrella is never a hands-free experience...That's the hook behind a flying umbrella built by YouTuber and maker John Xu of the I Build Stuff channel. He first built a drone-powered umbrella back in 2024, and it was, without question, an awesome feat. However, viewers were quick to point out the obvious flaw: it needed to be flown by a handheld controller… Xu spent the last two years working on a flying umbrella that did indeed follow him.

His first flying umbrella was unapologetically experimental. A self-built X-armed quadcopter powered the umbrella's flight, creating a sci-fi-like image of rain protection from above. It was equal parts clever and absurd – and it made its point. As a proof of concept, it showed that overhead rain cover was indeed possible. The downside was obvious, though: the umbrella had to be manually controlled. Rather than freeing up your hands, it required you to use both hands and added another device to manage. Viewers on YouTube were quick to call it out, with many echoing the same sentiment: "Now make it follow you."

This feedback was the basis of Xu's redesign, which he first started later in 2024… GPS tracking proved too coarse, with accuracy drifting by a few meters. And the fact he wanted to make the umbrella (and the drone at its heart) foldable added another layer of mechanical complexity.

The breakthrough came with a time-of-flight camera, which allowed the flying umbrella to track and follow a user directly, even in the dark. The umbrella wasn't perfect: it didn't stay perfectly overhead at all times, but worked well enough to completely transform the project. What started off as a striving novelty turned into something genuinely useful, and YouTube viewers took notice.

Of course, a flying umbrella raises just as many questions as it answers. Wind and heavy rain can easily push a lightweight drone off balance, and its battery life limits how long it can stay aloft above you. There's also the noise issue, and the somewhat awkward reality of spinning rotors whirring dangerously above people in public places.

For Xu, it wasn't about replacing umbrellas anytime soon; it was an experimental personal drone. And when he finally got it working, it was an impressive sight: hands-free rain protection, fairly consistent overhead coverage, and an elegant solution to an everyday hassle…Flying umbrellas are about to hit mass production...a playful, experimental symbol of what's becoming possible as sensors and autonomy move forward. It may never replace a good old umbrella, but it's a reminder that with a little imagination, even the most familiar objects can surprise us.

Source: I Build Stuff

WOOL NO LONGER WASTE

in the sheep farming regions of New South Wales, a peculiar transformation is underway. Spread across paddocks where crops have not grown properly for years, farmers are laying down a material that was, until very recently, considered a costly nuisance. The material is wool. Not the fine, export grade merino destined for suit jackets, but the coarse, thick, and often short fiber that accumulates in shearing sheds with no buyer and no purpose.

For years, the two problems existed in parallel. Soil scientists documented a steady decline in agricultural land, where organic matter had been farmed out of existence and rain no longer penetrated the surface. Meanwhile, graziers watched piles of unsold wool grow, paying for storage or disposal of a material that cost more to handle than it could ever fetch at market. The connection between these two failures was not immediately obvious. It is becoming clear now. The wool growing on the backs of 70 million sheep across Australia contains precisely the elements that degraded soil lacks. Nitrogen, sulfur, carbon, and a molecular structure engineered by evolution to manage moisture.

CAFFEINE AFFECTS COGNITION

After an analysis of data from over 131,000 people, researchers found that drinking coffee and tea daily seems to guard against the development of Alzheimer's disease and other forms of cognitive decline - caffeine may be the key protective compound. Using a statistical tool known as a Cox regression model, the researchers equalized the participants based on factors such as age, smoking status, BMI, physical activity, alcohol intake, depression, family history of dementia, medication use and more. This allowed them to focus exclusively on the intake of caffeinated beverages as a protective element in terms of dementia. Basically, it let them ask questions such as: "If two people are the same age, same weight, same smoking status, same blood pressure, similar diet quality — but one drinks more coffee — do we still see a difference in dementia risk?"

They did.

After splitting people into different categories of caffeine intake, and combing medical records for dementia as a cause of death or doctor diagnoses of the condition, they found that those who drank higher amounts of coffee had an 18% lower risk of developing dementia than those who drank the lowest amounts. Those in the highest tea-drinking group had a 14% lower risk, while those who drank the highest amounts of caffeine overall (from either coffee or tea or other caffeinated beverages) had a 22% reduced risk. Decaf coffee consumption was not shown to have any relation to dementia risk.

"*This finding suggests that caffeine may be the primary putative neuroprotective agent underlying the observed association*," write the researchers in their study, which has been published in the Journal of the American Medical Association.

ANTARCTIC GRAVITY HOLE

Antarctica is home to many mysteries, but one of the strangest is an enormous 'gravity hole' deep beneath the ice. Gravity might feel stable and constant wherever we go, but its strength actually varies over the Earth's surface. Where the gravity is weaker, the ocean's surface can actually dip well below the average as water rushes towards regions with higher gravity. Scientists have known for years that gravity is at its weakest in an area of Antarctica's Ross Sea, where sea levels dip 420 feet (130 m) below the surrounding water.

Now, a pair of researchers claim they finally know why.

The vast gravity hole, known as the Antarctic Geoid Low (AGL), is the product of incredibly slow rock movements, according to the experts. Starting 70 million years ago – a time while dinosaurs still roamed the Earth – less–dense rock built up beneath the frozen continent and weakened the pull of gravity. The gravity hole started small before rapidly growing in strength between 50 and 30 million years ago – creating the strange ocean dip that we see today…

To map how the Antarctic gravity hole formed, the researchers combined earthquake recordings from around the world with a computer model of the planet… By looking at how earthquakes travelled through different densities of rock, Dr Forte and his co–author constructed a map of the planet's inner workings. Using a computer model, they then worked out where the gravity would be stronger and weaker based on the different types of rock. Once their predictions matched the best current data from gravity–sensing satellites, they wound back the clock and watched as the gravity hole formed over aeons.

MAKING CEMENT 17X TOUGHER

Cement is one of the most widely used materials in construction, but it is also responsible for a significant portion of global greenhouse gas emissions. Engineers have long sought ways to improve cement's strength and durability, as its brittleness often leads to cracks and structural failure. In a surprising twist, a team at Princeton University turned to nature for inspiration, looking at the incredible toughness of oyster shells as a model for redesigning cement.

The key to this breakthrough lies in the shell of an oyster. Inside the shell, there is a material called nacre, or "mother of pearl," known for its impressive durability and flexibility. Nacre is made up of microscopic hexagonal plates of aragonite, a form of calcium carbonate, bound together by soft biopolymers. This combination of hard and soft components gives nacre its ability to absorb and distribute stress, preventing cracks from spreading.

By incorporating polymer layers between cement sheets and creating hexagonal patterns in the cement, it replicates the microscopic mechanics of nacre's durability. The results were impressive, with cement that was far more flexible and crack-resistant than the traditional material.